

THE REBEL RULES

As the Maoist leader takes over as the prime minister of Nepal, India may need to rejig its policy



Photographs by REUTERS

■ By Saurabh Shukla in Kathmandu

Democracy can be a great leveller, and as Pushpa Kamal Dahal a.k.a. Prachanda, took over as the prime minister of the new Republic of Nepal on August 18, the clock had turned a full-circle as the Nepal Army that had hunted him as its most wanted now gave him a salute.

As he took oath in the name of the people paying tribute to the people power, Prachanda couldn't have afforded himself more than a smile. Yes, his band of supporters did do the victory jig in the Ratna Park but just a little ahead, serpentine queues for petrol selling in black for Rs 100 reflected the many challenges that lie ahead. In rural Nepal, over 50,000 people are rendered homeless by floods while unemployment is at a record high of 15 per cent and climbing.

He has just about settled the arithmetic of politics by managing to wrest

the prime minister's post. Indeed the formation of the Cabinet was delayed because of squabbling amongst his allies. Maoists only control about 220 seats in the Constituent Assembly of 600 and their other allies may demand a heavy price for supporting his Government. The road ahead is less than smooth for the former rebel. A day before the swearing in ceremony, a bomb blast at the residence of the vice-president must have been a wake-up call on

RISING: Prachanda after taking oath

the unresolved security issues. Though a Maoist, he is bound by the constitution, and will have to traverse the long and winding path to fix the problems. The gun is no longer an option.

For the Himalayan nation, still in the midst of bouts of political uncertainty and instability, it is the dawn of a new era after a bloody insurgency that killed 15,000 people. In May, it became a republic and the 240-year-old monarchy was abolished. Gyanendra, the former king, now lives like a commoner in a government-owned palace.

The change of guard has brought some concerns for India. "We will judge him on his performance. He has to deliver it on the ground and we will support him," remarked an Indian diplomat. Interestingly, the Maoist leader's first stop for obeisance is not New Delhi but Beijing. Is that a sign that India should read into? It is early

INDIA'S WORRIES

- The country shares a 750-km open border with Nepal. It fears a Maoist regime could fuel problems in its own Naxal-infested areas.
- China's growing influence will erode its strategic space in Nepal
- Nepal may turn into a haven for anti-India terrorist groups